



UGO GUSSALLI
BERETTA

GREAT GUNSMITHS

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The world's oldest firearms manufacturer is the Italian company Fabbrica d'Armi Pietro Beretta SpA, which originated in the 16th century as a supplier of gun barrels to the arsenal in Venice. From these small beginnings, Beretta has expanded into a large business with a global reputation in a variety of fields—from small arms for military use to hand-made shotguns, often beautifully engraved. These guns continue to be recognized for their excellent design and high standard of quality under the able guidance of Ugo Gussalli Beretta and his sons.

In the 15th and 16th centuries, the city of Venice was a powerful and independent republic with lands in northern Italy and the Mediterranean. The Venetians grew rich through trade, and to help defend their empire, they developed the arsenal at Venice, originally a ship-building complex, as a major gun manufacturer. The arsenal called on craft workers from outside the city to supply parts for weapons. One of these craft workers was Mastro Bartolomeo Beretta, a gunsmith from

▼ BERETTA CRAFTSMAN

A worker assembles a hunting rifle at the Beretta factory in Italy in 1985. The stunning engraving on these premium weapons is done by hand and individually signed by the engraver.

Gardone Val Trompia in Lombardy, whose business began to prosper in 1526, when he supplied 185 harquebus barrels to the arsenal.

THE CRAFT TRADITION

The Venetians valued the work of gunsmiths such as Beretta and levied low taxes on them, giving them more power to run their own affairs and a ready market for their products. Mastro Bartolomeo Beretta, exploiting local deposits of high-grade iron ore to make his guns, did well, and he and his descendants handed down the techniques of gunsmithing from father to son from the 16th century to the present. Venice provided a strong market for Beretta's firearms until the city went into

decline in the 18th century. By this time, Beretta's weapons were well-known beyond the Venetian empire, so the company could still flourish as its initial market shrank. In the 19th century, Pietro Antonio Beretta and his son Giuseppe traveled up and down Italy demonstrating their company's products and collecting orders. Purchasers liked the quality, workmanship, and craft values of Beretta's products and the orders continued to flow in, especially for their finely crafted, ornately engraved rifles.

PRIZED FOR PRECISION

Throughout its history, the company has developed weapons for supply to a variety of military and civilian users. Its military weapons have moved with the times. For example, during World War I, the company developed the Model 1918, one of the first submachine-guns used by the Italian army. During the 20th century, Beretta handguns, especially its semiautomatic pistols, were widely employed by the military and police, and this has continued into the 21st century. Strength in this area is partly due to Pietro Beretta, who took over in 1903 and developed international sales, and partly to Tullio Marengoni, Beretta's chief designer from

